Web Design Pricing Research

MARKET ANALYSIS

Prepared for OphidianAI | Columbus, Indiana
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Executive Summary

This report analyzes web design pricing in the Columbus, Indiana market and across the US to inform OphidianAI's service pricing strategy. Key findings:

Limited local competition. Only one agency (MLT Innovations) is headquartered in Columbus, IN. Most competitors serve the area from Indianapolis or Bloomington.

Pricing is opaque. Almost no local agency publishes pricing. Transparent pricing is a clear differentiator.

The market floor is ~$1,200. Freelancers start around $1,200-$1,500 for basic sites. Agencies with a local presence start at $3,000-$5,000.

Subscription models are emerging. Monthly website + marketing bundles ($599-$1,599/mo) represent a recurring revenue opportunity.

National Pricing Snapshot

PROVIDER TYPE	PRICE RANGE
DIY Builders (Wix, Squarespace)	$240-$600/year
Freelance Designer	$1,500-$5,000
Boutique Agency	$6,000-$12,000
Experienced Professional (Custom)	$5,000-$20,000

Local Competitive Landscape

Agencies serving Columbus, IN and the surrounding Bartholomew County area.

MLT Innovations

Columbus, Indiana -- mltinnovations.com

Pricing: Not public. Custom quotes only.
Services: Custom web design, SEO, e-commerce, print design, aerial photography
Includes: Training, CMS, competitive market research
Notes: 30 years in business, 280+ clients. The only agency based in Columbus, IN.

Toohill Consulting

Bloomington, Indiana -- toohillconsulting.com

Pricing: "Starts at a few thousand dollars and grows upwards." Flexible payment plans.
Services: Website strategy, design, development (WordPress), SEO, paid ads, social media, branding
Includes: In-house coding, content/software updates, QA, post-launch management
Notes: 75+ five-star reviews, 100+ projects. Serves Columbus, IN. 1-3 month timeline.

Indy Web Design

Indianapolis, Indiana -- webdesignindy.com

Pricing: Starting around $1,200. Managed hosting from $59/month.
Services: Custom/WordPress design, managed hosting, Google Business, citation building, SEO, email marketing
Includes: Mobile responsive, up to 3 revisions, 30-day free support
Notes: Explicitly markets to Columbus, IN. 4 weeks to 3 months timeline.

Jessica Leigh Web Design

Edinburgh, Indiana -- jessicaleighwebdesign.com

Pricing: Not public. Positions as "affordable and professional."
Services: Web design, e-commerce, graphic design, SEO, logo design, hosting
Notes: Serves Bartholomew County directly. Solo/freelance operation.

Fayette Web Design

Greensburg, Indiana -- fayetteweb.com

Pricing: Packages start at $5,000.
Services: Custom website design/redesign, SEO campaigns, managed care plan
Includes: Hosting, maintenance, ongoing updates
Notes: Emphasizes ROI over low cost. Chamber member.

Indy Web Designers

Indianapolis, Indiana -- indywebdesigners.com

Pricing: Subscription model -- Starter $599/mo | Growth $1,199/mo | Premium $1,599/mo
Services: Bundled website + marketing (10-unlimited pages, social media, hosting, ad campaigns)
Includes: Hosting, security, unlimited revisions, strategy calls (Growth+)

Notes: Monthly subscription model. No upfront project fee.

National Pricing Benchmarks

Small Business Website Costs by Scope

SITE TYPE	FREELANCER	AGENCY
5-page brochure site	$1,000-$4,000	$3,000-$6,000
10-page standard site	$2,000-$5,000	$3,000-$10,000
Additional pages (each)	$100-$250	$100-$250
Basic e-commerce (<20 products)	$4,000-$8,000	$10,000-$30,000
Booking system add-on	$8-$50/month (SaaS plugin)	

What's Included at Each Tier

Basic ($500-$2,000)

- Template design with customization
- Up to 5 pages (home, about, services, contact)
- Contact form, photo gallery, social links
- Mobile responsive

Standard ($2,000-$5,000)

- Custom homepage design, 10 pages
- Blog functionality
- Social media integration
- Basic SEO optimization
- Basic e-commerce (limited products)
- Email marketing integration

Premium ($5,000-$10,000+)

- Fully custom design, 20+ pages
- Advanced animations/interactive elements
- Comprehensive online store
- Extensive SEO
- Content creation assistance
- Ongoing maintenance included
- Unlimited revisions

Common Pricing Models

MODEL	HOW IT WORKS	TYPICAL RANGE
Flat fee	One-time payment for defined scope. Most common.	$1,500-$12,000
Hourly rate	Billed per hour. Common for freelancers.	$50-$150/hr (freelancer) $75-$300/hr (agency)
Monthly retainer	Fixed monthly fee for ongoing work.	$2,000-$6,000/mo
Hybrid	Flat fee for build + hourly for extras.	Varies
Subscription	Monthly fee for "unlimited" design requests.	$1,000-$5,000/mo

Ongoing Services Pricing

Monthly Maintenance & Hosting

CATEGORY	RANGE
Basic hosting	$2-$200/month
Brochure site maintenance	$25-$100/month
Small business maintenance plan	$35-$500/month
E-commerce site maintenance	$750-$5,000/month

> **Rule of thumb:** Budget 15-30% of the initial build cost annually for maintenance.

SEO Services

TIER	MONTHLY COST
Minimum viable investment	$500/month
Small business typical	$500-$2,500/month
SEO specialist (hourly)	$100-$300/hour

Copywriting & Content

SERVICE	RANGE
Per-word rate	$0.15-$0.50/word
Blog post (500 words)	$200-$1,000
Full website content package	$5,000-$15,000

Local Market Pricing Reference

TIER	RANGE	TYPICAL SCOPE
Freelancer	$1,200-$4,000	5-page brochure site
Small agency	$3,000-$5,000+	5-10 page custom site
Mid-tier agency	$5,000-$15,000	10-30 page site with SEO
E-commerce	$10,000-$50,000+	Product catalog, cart, payments
Ongoing maintenance	$1,200-$3,000/year	Updates, security, hosting

TIER	RANGE	TYPICAL SCOPE
Managed hosting	$30-$200/month	Server, security, backups

Strategic Takeaways

Market Opportunity

- **Columbus, IN is underserved.** Only one local agency exists. Most competition comes from Indianapolis (1.5 hours away) or Bloomington. A local presence is a real advantage.
- **Transparent pricing wins.** Almost nobody in this market publishes pricing. Listing clear packages on your site removes friction and builds trust with small business owners who don't want to "request a quote."
- **AI is a genuine differentiator.** No local competitor is leveraging AI for faster delivery, better content, or smarter design. OphidianAI can deliver more for less and highlight the speed/quality advantage.

Pricing Position

> **Recommended approach:** Price at the low-to-mid range of agency rates while delivering premium quality. This undercuts established agencies while positioning above bargain freelancers.

CONSIDERATION	DETAIL
Market floor	~$1,200 (Indy Web Design). Going below this signals low quality.
Sweet spot for small business	$2,000-$5,000 for a 5-10 page site. Affordable but serious.
Agency premium range	$5,000-$12,000. Justified by custom design, SEO, content.
Monthly recurring	$50-$150/month for hosting + maintenance is standard and expected.

Recommended Next Steps

- Define 2-3 service packages (e.g., Starter, Professional, Premium) with clear scope and pricing
- Include hosting + maintenance as a monthly add-on for recurring revenue
- Publish pricing on the OphidianAI website -- transparency is a competitive advantage
- Consider a "Website in a Week" or fast-turnaround positioning leveraging AI speed
- Offer a content/copywriting add-on (AI-assisted) as an upsell

Sources

OneLittleWeb (2026) | GruffyGoat (2026) | Mark Brinker (2025) | WebyKing (2026) | Thervo (2026) | Elementor | Webstacks (2025) | Freshmove Media (2026) | Business.com (2026) | Shopify | Foxxr (2025) | EvenDigit | Eleken | Branded Agency (2026) | MLT Innovations | Toohill Consulting | Indy Web Design | Jessica Leigh Web Design | Fayette Web Design | Indy Web Designers